

Teshager Sisha

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EDUCATION

PhD. in Agricultural Economics, University of Kentucky	August 2026
MSc. in Economics, University of Kentucky	2024
MSc. in Economic Policy Analysis, Bahir Dar University	2015
BSc. in Statistics, Addis Ababa University	2003

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Health Economics; Applied Microeconomics; Public Policy; Food Policy

JOB MARKET PAPER

Fresh Produce Prices and Mental Health

This paper estimates the causal effect of local fresh-produce price increases on population mental health in the United States. Using county-level retail scanner data and repeated cross-sections of mental-health outcomes from BRFSS, I instrument produce prices with weather-driven supply shocks in major growing regions interacted with distance-based exposure measures. Higher produce prices significantly worsen population mental health, with larger effects in counties with limited baseline food access.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

1. Birhan Walie Alamneh, Demeke Lakew Workie, **Teshager Assefa Sisha**, Dereje Tesfaye Zekie, and Getachew Abate Dagnaw (2025). "Spatial distribution and determinants of saving habit and ownership of asset among households in Ethiopia: evidence from living standards measurement study 2018/19 data". In: *Discover Data* 3.1, p. 24. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s44248-025-00027-5>.
2. **Teshager Assefa Sisha**, Shuoli Zhao, and Yuqing Zheng (2025). "Psychological Well-Being and Child Tax Credit: Comparative Assessment of Payment Approaches". In: *Economics Letters*, p. 112494. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.econlet.2025.112494>.
3. Kassie Wubet Ebabu, Demeke Lakew Workie, Ashenafi Abate Woya, and **Teshager Assefa Sisha** (2024). "Spatially-informed insights into early marriage and school dropout: An advanced bivariate binary multilevel model for understanding Ethiopia's context". In: *Heliyon* 10.11, e32005. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2024.e32005>.

4. **Teshager Assefa Sisha** (2020). “Household level food insecurity assessment: Evidence from panel data, Ethiopia”. In: *Scientific African* 7, e00262. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sciaf.2019.e00262>.

WORK IN PROGRESS

- The WIC Cliff: Parental Mental Health Impacts from Benefit Transitions (Revise & Resubmit in *Health Economics*)

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- SAEA-2024, Atlanta, GA; SAEA-2025, Dallas, TX; SAEA-2026, Louisville, KY.
- AAFA-2024, New Orleans, LA.
- SEA-2025, Tampa, FL.
- IFAMA-2024, Almeria, Spain.

REVIEWER ROLES

Environmental Science and Pollution Research, The African Development Review, SSM - Population Health, Nutrition and Health, World Development Perspectives, African Journal of Science, Technology, Innovation and Development (×2), Open Agriculture (×2)

GRANT EXPERIENCE

Collaborator, USDA NIFA AFRI 2026–2030

PARTNERSHIP: From Data to Action – Developing and Evaluating the Beverage Choice Navigation Toolkit to Empower Healthier Decisions PI: S. Zhao (with S. Maksi, H. Norman-Burgdolf, Y. Zheng, Q. Li, L. Weddle, M. Jiang, O. Adedokun, J. Hunter \$1,150,000)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, University of Kentucky	2021–
Assistant Professor, Bahir Dar University	2019–2020
Lecturer, Bahir Dar University	2009–2018
Lecturer, University of Gondar	2003–2008

GRADUATE STUDENT ADVISING

- Birhan Walie – *Spatial distribution and determinants of saving habit and asset ownership*, Bahir Dar University, 2022–2023

- Asnakew Birie – *Exploring the spatial distribution of severe food insecurity in Ethiopia*, Bahir Dar University, 2022–2023

VISITING AND LEADERSHIP ROLES

- Visiting Scholar, Agricultural Economics, Texas A&M University, June–Oct 2016
- Research Team Coordinator, Innovation Lab for Small Scale Irrigation (ILSSI), 2014–2016
- Chair, Department of Statistics, Bahir Dar University, 2010–2012
- Chair, Department of Statistics, University of Gondar, 2004–2006

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP

American Agricultural Economics Association
Southern Agricultural Economics Association
Southern Economics Association

PERSONAL

Tech Skills STATA, R, Python, L^AT_EX
 US permanent Resident

REFERENCES

Yuqing Zheng – Professor, University of Kentucky	yuqing.zheng@uky.edu
Shuoli Zhao – Assistant Professor, University of Kentucky	szhao@uky.edu
Thomas Keene – Assistant Professor, University of Kentucky	keenetho@uky.edu
Haile Mekonen – Associate Professor, Bahir Dar University	haile.fenta@oulu.fi
Zelalem Getahun – Associate Professor, Bahir Dar University	DessieZ@ukzn.ac.za